

- RAG Learning

1.3 Global and Regional Variation

Edexcel A-Level English Language (9EN0) — Paper 1 Language Variation

This topic covers how English varies across UK regions and around the world. You need to know **UK dialects**, **Kachru's Three Circles of World Englishes**, **ELF** (Jennifer Jenkins), contact varieties including **MLE**, **AAVE**, pidgins and creoles. Top-band answers integrate attitudes (standard-language ideology) with linguistic description.

1.3.1 UK Regional Varieties

Variety	Typical features
Cockney	H-dropping ("ouse"), t-glottalisation ("be'er"), th-fronting ("fink"), rhyming slang
Estuary English	Middle ground between RP and Cockney — spreading across SE England
Geordie (Tyneside)	Distinctive vowels; "pet", "howay", "bairn", "nowt"
Scouse (Liverpool)	Velar fricatives; affrication of /t/ and /k/; "made up" = pleased
Yorkshire	Short /a/ in "bath"; definite-article reduction ("t' pub"); "owt/nowt"
West Country	Rhotic /r/ after vowels; "ee" for "he"; rural "thee/thou"
Welsh English	Sing-song intonation; invariant tag "isn't it"; Welsh-origin lexis
Scottish English	Rolled /r/; "wee", "bairn", "dreich"; distinctive modal use

The UK shows enormous variation in tiny distances — a recognised feature not found in all global Englishes. Paul Kerswill's work on **dialect levelling** shows mobility and media are reducing distinctive local features, though new varieties (MLE) emerge alongside.

1.3.2 Multicultural London English (MLE)

MLE emerged in late-20th / early-21st century London through dense multiethnic peer networks. Researched by **Jenny Cheshire, Paul Kerswill** and colleagues.

Features

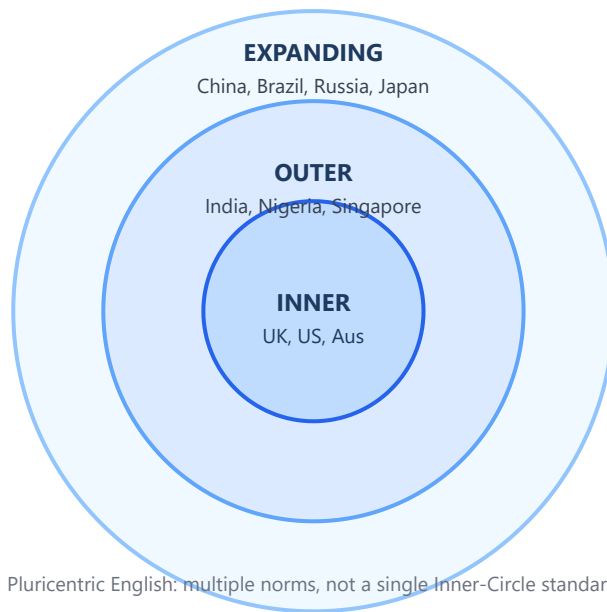
- **Vowels** — fronted GOOSE; distinctive FACE, GOAT vowels.
- **Lexis** — "ting" (thing), "mandem" (group of men), "wasteman" (useless person). Drawn from Caribbean, South Asian, West African and vernacular London sources.
- **Grammar** — "man" as indefinite pronoun ("man's tired"); new quotatives "this is me...".
- **Prosody** — distinctive intonation contours.

Key finding: MLE features are shared across ethnic lines in multiethnic peer networks — it is a *community of practice* variety, not tied to any single ethnicity.

Media representations ("jafaican", "street slang") often frame MLE pejoratively — a textbook example of **standard-language ideology** treating rule-governed innovation as threat.

1.3.3 Kachru's Three Circles

Kachru's Three Circles of World Englishes



- **Inner Circle** — English as native (UK, US, Canada, Australia, NZ). "Norm-providing".
- **Outer Circle** — English as institutionalised second language often from colonisation (India, Nigeria, Singapore, Ghana, Kenya). Developing local norms.
- **Expanding Circle** — English as foreign / international (China, Brazil, Russia, Japan). Traditionally "norm-dependent" but increasingly developing local norms through ELF.

Criticism: the model risks reinforcing Inner-Circle hegemony. Reality is fluid — many Expanding-Circle speakers are highly proficient; Indian English is pluricentric in its own right; boundaries blur.

1.3.4 English as a Lingua Franca (ELF) — Jenkins

Jennifer Jenkins argues that for communication between non-native speakers (the majority of global English use), Inner-Circle norms are not the relevant target. She proposes a **Lingua Franca Core**: only certain phonological features are essential for intelligibility (e.g. consonant clusters), while exact RP vowels are not.

Implication: "correct" English in ELF contexts is defined by intelligibility, not by native-speaker conformity.

1.3.5 Crystal and Pluricentric English

David Crystal's work argues that English has produced multiple **new Englishes**, each with legitimate norms. With roughly **1.5 billion speakers** worldwide — only about 390 million of them native (*Ethnologue*, 2025) — the idea of a single "correct" English is incompatible with how English is actually used. Crystal's position is broadly descriptivist.

1.3.6 Translanguaging — García

Ofelia García's concept of **translanguaging** treats multilingual speakers as having a single integrated repertoire deployed flexibly, rather than switching between bounded languages. Reframes code-switching and code-mixing: not switches between separate systems, but fluent use of one holistic resource.

1.3.7 AAVE (African American Vernacular English)

Labov's Harlem research (1972) demonstrated AAVE is a rule-governed, systematic variety. Features:

Feature	Example
Habitual "be"	"She be working" = she works regularly
Copula deletion	"She happy"
Remote past "been"	"I been done my homework"
Negative concord	"Don't nobody know"
Cluster reduction	"tes" for "test"

Labov's work was influential in the **Ann Arbor decision** (1979), which ruled that schools must acknowledge AAVE as a legitimate variety. The Ebonics debate (1996) showed how linguistic facts are filtered through racialised ideologies.

1.3.8 Other World Englishes

Variety	Key features
Indian English	"Prepone"; progressive with stative verbs ("I am understanding"); invariant tag "isn't it?"
Singlish	Final particles "lah", "lor", "meh"; topic-prominent syntax; Malay/Hokkien/Tamil/Cantonese influence
Nigerian English	"Go-slow" = traffic jam; distinctive modal use; Yoruba/Igbo/Hausa loans
Jamaican Creole	"Mi" for "I"; copula deletion; aspectual markers
Scots	Long sister-variety of English with strong grammatical and lexical distinctness

1.3.9 Pidgins and Creoles

- **Pidgin** — simplified contact language, no native speakers.
- **Creole** — a pidgin becoming a community's native language, with expanded grammar.
- **Decreolisation** — movement towards prestige, producing a **lectal continuum** from basilect through mesolect to acrolect.

1.3.10 Code-Switching vs Code-Mixing

- **Code-switching** — alternating across clauses/turns. Functions: audience design, identity, topic, quotation.
- **Code-mixing** — mixing elements within a clause. Common in Hinglish, Spanglish.
- Both are skilled competences, not deficits.

1.3.11 Vitality and Attitudes

Howard Giles: **ethnolinguistic vitality** depends on demographic strength, institutional support and status. Varieties with low vitality face potential decline. Attitudes shape vitality — positive media, education and policy can reinforce or erode a variety.

Applied Example: When British tabloids label MLE "jafaican", they are doing ideological work: implying MLE is fake / inauthentic / a threat. Cheshire's research shows MLE is a rule-governed variety emerging from multiethnic peer networks — demonstrably authentic linguistic innovation. Analysing such representations is a language-discourse exercise.

1.3.12 How to Analyse World Englishes Texts

1. Identify the **variety** and place it in Kachru's framework.
2. Analyse specific **features** at phonology, lexis, grammar.
3. Consider the **sociocultural context** — history, contact, identity.
4. Apply **theorists**: Kachru, Crystal, Jenkins, Labov, Cheshire & Kerswill, García.
5. Evaluate **attitudes and representations**.
6. Avoid deficit framing — all rule-governed varieties are legitimate.

Exam Tip: Engage with attitudes explicitly. A high-quality answer on MLE or AAVE acknowledges that these varieties are often unfairly stigmatised AND explains why the stigma is linguistically unfounded. This is where AO1, AO2 and AO3 meet.

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define: **dialect, accent, Kachru's Three Circles (Inner/Outer/Expanding), ELF, Lingua Franca Core, translanguaging, pluricentrism, ethnolect, MLE, AAVE, pidgin, creole, basilect / mesolect / acrolect, lectal continuum, code-switching, code-mixing, ethnolinguistic**

vitality, standard-language ideology, dialect levelling. Theorists: **Kachru, Crystal, Jenkins, Labov, Cheshire & Kerswill, García, Giles.**